Unshackled from the threat of further action, Honecker used an interview with a West German magazine to let off steam without worrying about the public reaction. Talking to SUPERillu, he criticised Mikhail Gorbachev and Egon Krenz, saying they ‘betrayed the socialist camp’. As far as he was concerned, ‘Gorbachev was finished’. He freely admitted to making mistakes during his time in government but insisted ‘one should not put all the blame’ on him. ‘Many problems were caused by other people; Mr. Kohl knows that.’ In unvarnished language, he rattled on about a new united Germany, predicting a ‘black, black, black’ future, expressing relief he did not have to solve the problems of that country. He had no complaints whatever against life in Chile, but sometimes felt homesick but ‘not for the Berlin of today’. He forced a sour smile when revealing he was unsure about returning to Germany – or even if he could live there in freedom. He did disclose, however, that he was composing his memoirs ‘for the German youth … so they could learn the full truth’.

While continuing this revealing dialogue, he snapped at accusations that he was responsible for the deaths of innocent people: ‘The West German press is lying through its teeth,’ he asserted, closing the subject which remained off-limits. Health wise, he felt ‘sometimes well, sometimes less well’, he moved more slowly and had gotten used to the pains. ‘I still feel strong,’ he chivalrously remarked.11 However, not long after unburdening himself to SUPERillu, his health took a dramatic turn for the worse. Indeed, medical records show he received several blood transfusions but was weakened by an ineffable weariness. According to Juan Carlos Arriagada, a Chilean neighbour, Honecker still managed to ‘closely follow the fate of his comrades in Germany’ and was horrified when Defence Minister Heinz Kessler, and his deputy Fritz Streletz, were found guilty on charges of incitement to commit manslaughter, while Hans Albrecht was convicted of aiding and abetting manslaughter. ‘These sentences came as bitter blows to both Margot and Erich,’ said Ed Stuhler. ‘It certainly didn’t help his health.’ Over the coming month, Honecker barely left the neighbourhood, his daily exercise was a slow stroll out in the yard and around the house, always alone, always in silence. Then as the cold weather of the southern hemisphere winter set in, he remained virtually bedridden in a small room on the ground floor where the thermostat had been pre-set to 22°C.